due for some leave by then. Even though Isha was only in Class I, we had decided that we would never miss out on school days. We were always back in time for the new session, and in a way, it rubbed off on the kids to take education seriously.

One evening towards the end of my tenure, Brig Sandhu called me up, asking me what I was doing. It was about 7.30 p.m. and I told him, 'Nothing much, just tying up details for the next day'. 'Come up here (to his residence) immediately,' he said and hung up the phone. I hastily exited, telling my runner to close the office and took the short walk up to the Flag Staff House, wondering what sins I might have committed. He greeted me cordially at the entrance and after offering me a seat, opened a bottle of Scotch whisky (it was still a rarity). We spent the evening chatting about this and that. Brig Sandhu was in an expansive mood and I was left wondering about this sudden social call. The next day, the results of the promotion board from Brigadier to Major General were announced and lo and behold, Brig Sandhu's name was on the approved list. The mystery of the previous evening's call was resolved. Obviously, he had come to know of the result and wanted to share his success with someone. Who else could he call upon than his Brigade Major, his right-hand man? That does not mean we did not have our differences. During briefings and presentations, even in the presence of the COs and Brigade Officers, I would have heated arguments with him, even threatening to walk out on one occasion. Brig Sandhu called me back when I was at the door, and I had the good sense to return. Discretion is the better part of valour. Of all the bosses I have had, I would rate Brig Surat Singh Sandhu as one of the best.[3]

During this period, the unit, after completing its peace tenure at Gwalior, had moved to Kaksar near Kargil as part of 121 (I) Infantry Brigade Group. This was a high-altitude

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